

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Automation Roadmap

Sequence an automation programme into stabilise-then-grow phases with outcomes leadership can track.

Purpose

This roadmap turns automation from an open-ended activity into a phased programme with clear outcomes, owners and exit criteria for each phase. It is deliberately outcome-led — each phase is defined by the confidence or capability it delivers, not by a test count — so that progress is visible to leadership and the programme cannot quietly become "add tests forever".

When to use it

- When you have assessed the current state and need a fundable, staged plan to improve it.
- When leadership wants to see where "more automation" is going and when it pays off.
- When you need to sequence stabilisation before growth so you do not build on sand.

Instructions

1. Start from your Automation Assessment score so the roadmap targets your real weak points.
2. Define phases by outcome (stabilise → shift down the pyramid → integrate into CI → grow coverage), not by dates alone.
3. Give every phase an owner, an exit criterion and a success measure that is not a raw test count.
4. Sequence so trust and stability come first; never grow coverage on top of a flaky base.
5. Review at each phase gate and only start the next phase when the exit criterion is met.

Worked example

A staged roadmap for Northstar, starting from its 33/100 assessment, ~25% flake and QA-only ownership. Timescales are indicative planning estimates, not commitments:

Phase	Outcome	Key actions	Owner	Exit criterion / measure
0 · Stabilise (Q1)	A trustworthy signal	Quarantine the flakiest ~25%; fix or delete; agree a flake policy	Automation engineer + QA	Flake rate below 5%; green means green

Phase	Outcome	Key actions	Owner	Exit criterion / measure
			lead	
1 · Shift down (Q2)	Faster, cheaper coverage	Move payment/discount logic to API + unit tests; keep 1-2 UI journeys	Squad devs + QA	Core logic covered below UI; run time under 1 hour
2 · Integrate (Q2-Q3)	Feedback where it counts	Wire the fast suite into CI to gate pull requests	Platform squad + QA	Suite gates every PR; developers act on failures
3 · Shared ownership (Q3)	No key-person risk	Developers write and own tests for their squad; QA coaches	Squad leads	Each squad owns its own checks; Dan no longer sole owner
4 · Grow to risk (Q4+)	Coverage where risk is	Extend against the Candidate Matrix, highest risk first	All squads	Escaped-defect trend down; coverage tracks risk, not vanity

The sequence is the message: Northstar does not add a single new test until Phase 0 has restored trust. Ownership is fixed (Phase 3) before coverage grows (Phase 4), directly addressing the single-owner risk around Dan and the low trust from the failed "automate everything" push.

STABILISE BEFORE YOU GROW

Adding coverage to a flaky suite multiplies the flakiness. Phase 0 exists precisely so you never build new tests on an untrustworthy base.

Blank reusable version

Phase	Outcome	Key actions	Owner	Exit criterion / measure
0 · Stabilise				
1 · Shift down pyramid				
2 · Integrate into CI				
3 · Shared ownership				
4 · Grow to risk				

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Sequencing by date instead of by outcome; growing coverage before stabilising, so flakiness compounds; measuring phases by test count rather than by trust, speed or escaped defects; leaving ownership with one person while piling on more tests; and starting the next phase before the current exit criterion is met.

How to interpret the results

- If you cannot state a phase's exit criterion without using a test count, the outcome is not yet well defined.

- A roadmap that reaches "grow coverage" before "shared ownership" is fragile; expect the new tests to rot.
- Slipping phase gates are data — they usually reveal stabilisation was underestimated, not that the plan is wrong.
- Success is a falling escaped-defect trend and a faster release, not a rising number of automated checks.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Sell the roadmap by its Phase 0 promise: "we will make the automation trustworthy before we make it bigger". Leadership has usually been burned by a previous "automate everything" drive — as Northstar was — and a leader who visibly stabilises first earns the credit to fund everything after.